

Diagnose Your Team Together With The Zombie Scrum Symptom Checker

A simple experiment to create transparency around the areas where your Scrum Team is doing well and where they can improve - together



Purpose Of This Experiment

[Zombie Scrum](#) is on the rise! Although it may look like Scrum from a distance, with all the roles, events and artifacts you'd expect, it turns out to be anything but on closer inspection. There is no valuable Increment at the end of a Sprint, stakeholders are not involved, autonomy is very low and nobody is trying to improve anything about the situation.

This experiment is all about helping your team get clear on where they stand between Professional Scrum and Zombie Scrum. Although the results may be painful, it is better to face the truth and make your first steps towards recovery.

Diagnose your team

Is your team suffering from Zombie Scrum? Something that looks like Scrum from a distance, but is missing a beating heart of valuable software. Find out with our symptom tracker.

To date, 1489 teams have participated

Start

Why you should try

1. Its 100% free. No registration required.
2. Created and refined with ongoing input from the global Scrum community.
3. As private and anonymous as you want.
4. Afterwards, you receive a report with your results and suggestions for things to try.
5. Invite your team to see if they feel the same.
6. We use scientifically validated metrics.
7. We don't sell your data or send you spam.



Christian Vorwies



Johannes Schartau



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Need more help?

We are currently writing a book to help Scrum Teams in need. Addison-Wesley has scheduled the release for Q2 2020. Want to receive an autographed copy? [Sign up here.](#)

Infection Tracker

■ Average □ Most teams (1489)

Ship Fast

ZOMBIE SCRUM HEALTHY SCRUM

Improve Continuously

ZOMBIE SCRUM HEALTHY SCRUM

Build What The Customer Needs

ZOMBIE SCRUM HEALTHY SCRUM

Self-Organize

ZOMBIE SCRUM HEALTHY SCRUM

Valuable Outcomes

ZOMBIE SCRUM HEALTHY SCRUM

Difficulty / Effort

Required Skill	★☆☆☆☆	No skill is required for filling in a survey and inspecting the results together with your team.
Impact On Survival	★★★★★	This experiment creates transparency around what is going on in your team (and around it) in terms of Zombie Scrum. It's a crucial first step on your way to recovery.

Steps

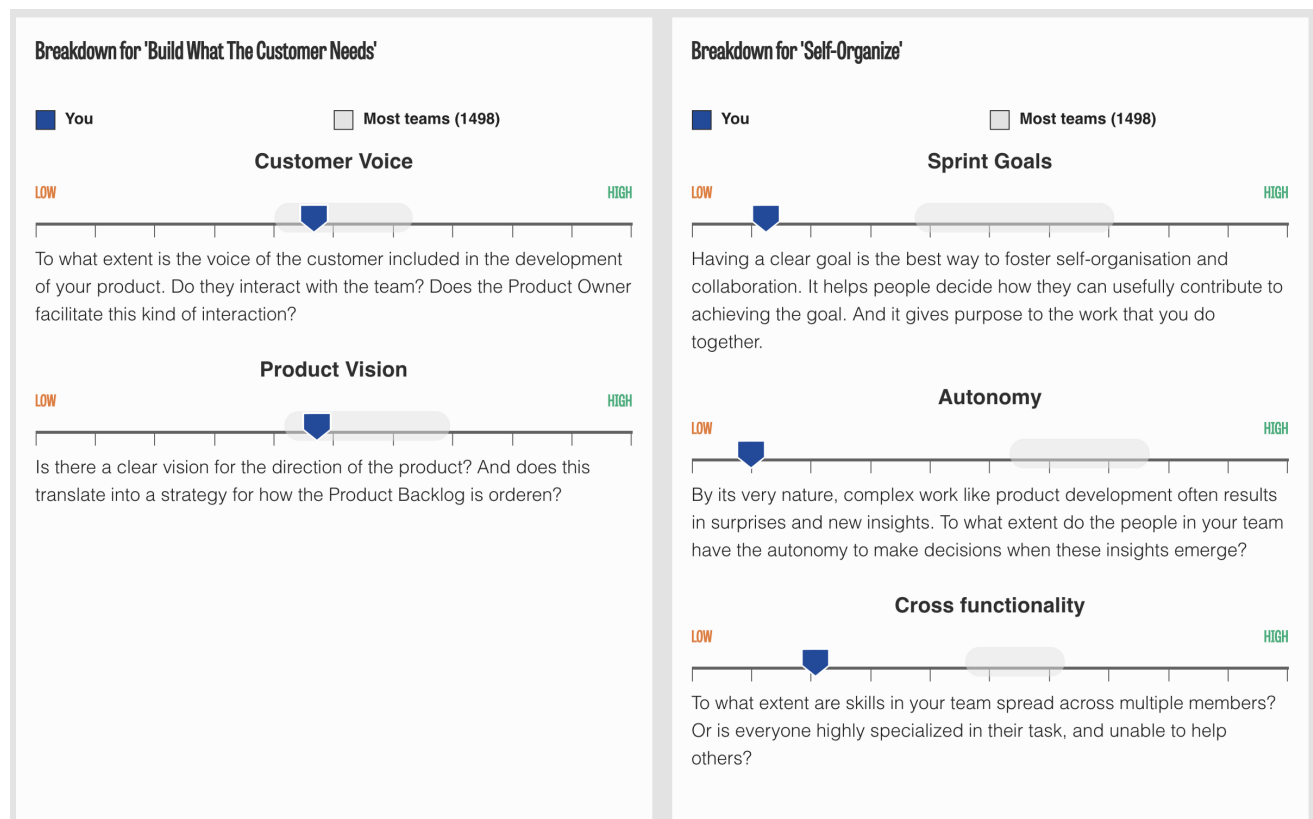


To implement this experiment, do the following:

1. Go to <https://survey.zombiescrum.org> and fill out the extensive free survey for your Scrum Team. After you have completed the first survey invite others from your team to join your 'sample' as instructed by the site. To protect the privacy of participants and to avoid abuse, individual scores are only shown to the participants themselves.
2. When you complete the survey, you receive a detailed report. The report is updated every time someone joins the sample. In the report, we offer you scores on the four key symptoms of Zombie Scrum, as well as a more detailed break-down. The report also gives feedback and recommendations based on that. When everyone has participated, schedule a 1-hour workshop to inspect the results together. We recommend to do this with only the Scrum Team;
3. Prepare for the workshop. Print the report and hand them out, put prints on the walls or simply put up the profile on a screen;
4. Start the workshop by reiterating the purpose clearly and emphasize what will happen with the outcomes (and what won't). Make sure to emphasize that improvement is always a gradual, incremental, and often messy process and that this workshop is a step in that process;
5. Invite everyone to silently inspect the results and note down observations. Ask: "What do you notice in the results?". Encourage people to stick to the facts, and avoid jumping to conclusions, for the first round. After a few minutes, ask people to share their observations in pairs for another couple of minutes and notice similarities and differences. If you have eight or more people, ask pairs to join another pair and take a few minutes to share observations and notice patterns. Ask the small groups to share their most important insights with the whole group, and capture them in a way that remains visible to everyone present;
6. Repeat twice more with different questions, using the pattern outlined earlier. For round 2, ask people: "So, what does this mean for our work as a team?" For round 3, ask people: "Where do we have the freedom and autonomy to improve as a team? What are small, first steps we can commit to?" Make sure to keep gathering the outcomes;
7. Put the most important actionable improvement on the Sprint Backlog for the next Sprint. Involve others as needed to keep making progress. Use the Sprint Retrospective to explore what has changed and improved.



How To Use The Report



Detailed Breakdown of the Results

The report you receive after participating in the survey contains not only a high-level overview but also a detailed breakdown of the results. For example, the visualization below shows how the team used 'Customer Voice' and 'Product Vision' as part of the theme 'Build What the Customer Needs'. The breakdown of 'Self-Organize' shows the detailed results for using 'Sprint Goal', 'Autonomy', and 'Cross Functionality'. These detailed results give the team the opportunity for a closer inspection and define improvements accordingly.

During the workshop, you can first explore the high-level results per theme, and then study the detailed results for the ones that stand out the most.

Feedback on the results

Based on the answers the team members provided in the survey, detailed feedback is provided. It consists of recommendations for experiments to conduct, articles to read, videos to watch, and podcasts to listen to. Use this detailed feedback as inspiration for the workshop. It's helpful to study the feedback upfront and ask everyone to share the key takeaways during the workshop.

How to destroy trust and transparency

When you create transparency in this manner, it is very easy to destroy it. And so is the trust that comes with it. For example, you may be tempted to compare Scrum Teams within your organization. Especially when teams are rewarded for their results, this may lead them to game their results and make themselves look best on paper – its only human to do so.

Management may be tempted to ask you for reports. However, do not share anything with anyone outside the team else unless every member of your team unequivocally consents. Don't apply pressure of any kind and don't share anything when even a single person objects. Once people feel that they are being controlled through these reports, all transparency (and trust) will be lost.

In principle, do not ask people to share their individual scores. There may be cases where this is helpful, but that only works when psychological safety is very high. Furthermore, the scores in the profile are really the most meaningful on the level of the team. Individual scores are generally quite noisy because of slightly different interpretations, situational and personal differences.

In short, practice the Scrum Values. Be open with each other while respecting each other's privacy. Be courageous to reject attempts from outsiders to view reports or compare teams. Commit to inspecting the result of the team, not individuals. And focus on the improvements that make you a better team.

Our Findings

- It can be tempting to identify dozens of potential improvements and end up doing nothing at all. Instead, keep a strong focus on improving one thing first before moving onto something else. If that improvement is too big to commit to doing it in a single Sprint, make it smaller;
- When you ask people to participate in this survey, you're asking them to trust you with their honest answers. Be deeply respectful of that. Don't spread reports outside of the team, forward it to management or use it to compare teams. Violating this will erode trust much faster than you can rebuild it;
- Use the outcome of the survey as a conversation starter. Not a judgment tool. It's about making the state of the Scrum Team transparent, inspecting the results together, and spark adaptation accordingly;
- Make sure the entire Scrum Team participates in the workshop. Not only the Product Owner and Scrum Master. Otherwise, it will quickly become a tool to assess the Development Team. This will not only damage trust but entirely misses the point of the survey.
- Frequently conduct the survey with the entire team. Don't do it once. Make it a recurring activity. This allows the team to learn what has changed over time, and what didn't. These are probably the more challenging things to change and might need a different approach.
- Ask other teams to do the survey as well. When the organization consists of multiple Scrum Teams, invite them to fill in the survey as well. This allows you to discover patterns or things that are completely different. What is it that the teams have in common? What seems to be a challenge in the organization? So what should all the teams try to improve?

More Resources

- Blogpost: [The 4 Core Symptoms of Zombie Scrum](#)
- Tool: [The Zombie Scrum First Aid Kit](#) is a great way to periodically create transparency.
- Blogpost: [How we improved the Zombie Scrum Survey](#)

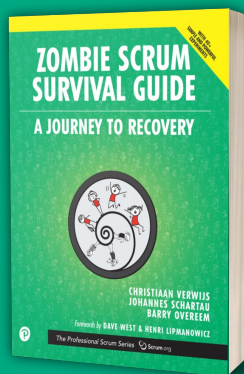
Help Us With Your Feedback



We are eager to learn how this experiment benefitted your team. What did it make possible? How did it help you make progress in your recovery from Zombie Scrum? With your data, we can improve our recommendations to other teams. You can share [your feedback](#) here with us in a only few minutes.



The Zombie Scrum Survival Guide



Zombie Scrum is on the rise! What may look like Scrum from a distance often turns out to be anything but when you take a closer look. Although teams go through the motions of Scrum, Sprints don't result in valuable outcomes, customers are not involved, teams have little autonomy and nobody is doing anything to improve.

A detailed examination of Zombie Scrum

In our book, we share our research and experience in the field with Zombie Scrum. We explore symptoms and causes, and dig deep into why Zombie Scrum usually starts when the purpose of Scrum isn't clear. With our book, the purpose of Scrum was never this clear!

Start your recovery tomorrow

The good news is that recovery is entirely possible. Our book contains over 40 practical experiments to start recovery, even when your organization has succumbed to it completely.

Get your copy now

You can find the 'Zombie Scrum Survival Guide' in your favorite bookstore starting from November 23, 2020. Or buy your copy from us at zombiescrum.org. The book comes with a free digital first aid kit, and a nice discount for a physical kit.



The Zombie Scrum Resistance

The 'Zombie Scrum Survival Guide' is written by Christiaan Verwijns, Johannes Schartau and Barry Overeem, and richly illustrated by Thea Schukken.